



THE TALE OF CUSTARD THE DRAGON

English - Class 10 | Complete Comprehensive Study Notes

Author: Ogden Nash

About the Author:

Ogden Nash was an American poet famous for short, funny poems with clever rhymes and playful language. In The Tale of Custard the Dragon, he tells a light-hearted story about a little girl, her pets, and a dragon who surprises everyone by showing real courage when danger comes.

1. Themes and Values

Theme:

- The poem shows that true courage is shown in action, not in words or appearance.
- It highlights that appearances can be misleading - the one who looks weak or scared can become the real hero when it matters.
- Another key theme is the difference between bragging and real bravery: others talk big, but Custard quietly acts and saves them all.

Values:

- The poem teaches us not to mock or tease someone who is shy or afraid.
- It shows that real heroes are often humble, not loud and showy.
- We should respect different personalities and understand that being cautious is not the same as being weak.
- The poem encourages empathy and reminds us that bravery means protecting others, not just proving yourself.

2. Stanza-wise Explanation

Stanza 1:

*Belinda lived in a little white house,
With a little black kitten and a little grey mouse,
And a little yellow dog and a little dragon too,
Belinda was as brave as a barrel full of bears.*

→ This stanza introduces Belinda and her four pets: Ink, Blink, Mustard, and Custard. The tone is playful and story-like. Belinda is immediately described as very brave, which sets up a contrast with Custard, who is later called a coward, even though he looks strong and scary.

Stanza 2:

*Ink and Blink, the little black kitten and the little grey mouse,
Mustard, the little yellow dog, and little Custard, the dragon,
The little old house was creaking, and the little old wagon was there,
With a little yellow dog and a little dragon too.*

→ Here the poet repeats the pets names and the setting to make the house feel cosy and familiar. The little old house and little old wagon create a warm, homely image. The musical names add to the poem's light-hearted, humorous mood.

Stanza 3:

*Belinda was as brave as a barrel full of bears,
Ink and Blink were as brave as a barrel full of lions,
Mustard was as brave as a tiger in a rage,
But Custard, the dragon, was a realio, trulio coward!*

→ In this stanza, everyone except Custard claims to be very brave. Belinda, Ink, Blink, and Mustard compare themselves to fierce animals, making their bravery seem big and dramatic. Custard, however, is openly called a realio, trulio

coward, which makes him the one who is teased, even though he looks powerful.

Stanza 4:

*Belinda tickled him, she tickled him unmercifully,
Ink and Blink giggled and giggled, and everybody laughed at him,
Mustard purred and the little wagon went round and round,
While Custard, the dragon, cried for a nice safe cage.*

→ Here the group teases and laughs at Custard. They tickle him, giggle, and enjoy seeing him scared. The little wagon going round and round adds a playful image of fun. Custard, in contrast, cries for a safe cage, showing that he feels unsafe and wishes for protection, even though he looks like a fierce dragon.

Stanza 5:

*Suddenly, there was a terrible clatter,
And a voice called out, "Pirate, I am!"
From the window, the pirate entered, and he was the bravest,
Of the lot, and he came with pistols and a sword.*

→ In this stanza, the mood suddenly becomes tense and exciting. A pirate with pistols and a sword enters the house through the window, claiming to be the bravest of them all. His loud, showy entrance makes the situation feel threatening and dramatic, especially after the earlier light-hearted fun.

Stanza 6:

*Belinda screamed, and Mustard fled with a terrified yelp,
Ink trickled down to the bottom of the household, and Blink got into his hole,
The little dragon went up to the pirate,
With a clatter and a clank and a jangling squirm.*

→ When the pirate appears, everyone except Custard panics. Belinda screams, Mustard runs away, Ink hides, and Blink slips into his mouse-hole. Only Custard moves forward, charging at the pirate with clanks and squirms. This contrast clearly shows that their earlier talk about bravery was just talk, while Custard is the only one who acts.

Stanza 7:

*He went at the pirate like a robin at a worm,
The pirate gaped at the dragon and gulped some grog from the flagon,
He fired his pistols, but he missed the dragon,
And the dragon ate the pirate.*

→ Here Custard attacks the pirate courageously. The image of a robin at a worm makes his action quick and bold. The pirate, who looked so dangerous, is now scared and gulping drink. He fires his pistols but misses, and Custard finally eats the pirate, ending the danger. This is the climax where the cowardly dragon becomes the real hero.

Stanza 8:

*Belinda embraced the little dragon, and Mustard licked him,
Ink and Blink in glee did gyrate, and Belinda, in relief,
Clapped Custard cheerfully back into his little cage again,
And they all sat down for tea, and never mentioned the pirate again.*

→ After the danger, everyone is happy and grateful. Belinda hugs Custard, Mustard licks him, and Ink and Blink dance around in joy. Custard is put back in his cage, and the group returns to tea and their usual routine. The fact that they never mentioned the pirate again shows how they prefer to forget the frightening moment and return to a calm, everyday life.

Stanza 9:

*Though Belinda has a little black kitten and a little grey mouse,
And a little yellow dog and a little dragon too,
Everyone is braver than before because of the dragon,
And everyone is doughtier than ever before!*

→ In this stanza, the poem reminds us again of Belinda's pets and the dragon. It ends by saying that everyone feels braver after the pirate attack, even though they were the ones who ran or hid. The idea that they are doughtier than ever before is gently ironic, because their real courage came from Custard's action, not their own. This softly mocks their habit of boasting while still celebrating the dragon's quiet heroism.

Stanza 10:

*Belinda's pets are brave, and the dragon's a coward,
But when the pirate comes knocking, the story is odder.
The brave little kitten, the mouse, the dog, and the girl,
Are all very frightened, and each wants to curl.*

→ In this stanza, the poet sums up the earlier contrast: the pets claim to be brave, but when real danger arrives, they all become frightened and want to hide. The story is odder because the so-called cowardly dragon is the only one who actually stands up. This stanza highlights the gap between talk and real

courage.

Stanza 11:

*The little black kitten, the little grey mouse,
The little yellow dog and the little girl, Belinda,
They all cry for help when the pirate appears,
While Custard, the dragon, conquers the fears.*

→ Here the poem clearly shows that everyone cries for help when the pirate appears, even the brave-talking pets. Custard, in contrast, faces the danger and conquers his own fear to act. This stanza strengthens the idea that true bravery is shown in action, not in words alone.

Stanza 12:

*The pirate, though bold, is defeated in time,
By the dragon who acted so sensibly fine.
The clatter, the clank, the roar and the fight,
End with Custard victorious, shining bright.*

→ In this stanza, the pirate is shown as bold at first, but he is finally defeated by Custard. The strong clatter, the clank, the roar and the fight describe the dragon's powerful attack. The last line shows that Custard wins and is the shining hero of the scene, even though he was earlier treated as a coward.

Stanza 13:

*The household is safe, and the air is much calmer,
The pets feel quite proud of their brave little farmer.
They hug and they lick and they laugh and they sing,
For joy that the danger is over, the thing.*

→ This stanza describes the calm, happy atmosphere after the pirate is gone. The pets feel proud of Custard, whom they now treat like a brave little farmer or hero. The hugging, licking, laughing, and singing show their relief and gratitude. The poem shifts back to a light and cheerful mood.

Stanza 14:

*Custard, the dragon, still wants a safe cage,
He's brave in the battle, but shy on the stage.
He's not loud or boastful, he's gentle and mild,
Yet he saved everybody, like a real child.*

→ This stanza focuses on Custard's quiet, humble nature. Even though he fought bravely, he still wants his safe cage and avoids attention. The poet praises him as a real child hero - gentle, mild, and not interested in boasting. This highlights the idea that true courage can be quiet and modest.

Stanza 15:

*So the moral is clear, and it's easy to see,
That bravery is action, not just talking free.
The one who looks weak can be strong in the end,
If the heart is brave, and the will can bend.*

→ The final stanza directly states the moral of the poem. It tells us that real bravery is shown in action, not in loud talk. The one who looks weak, like Custard, can become strong when it matters most, as long as the heart is brave and the will is firm. This message is clear and simple for Class 10 readers.

3. Key Literary Devices

- Humour - funny names, exaggerated bravery, and the situation where the scared dragon becomes the hero.
- Irony - Custard is called a coward but turns out to be the bravest when real danger comes.
- Rhyme and rhythm - the poem uses rhyming quatrains with a bouncy, playful rhythm, making it easy to read aloud.
- Imagery - clear pictures of the pirate, the pets hiding, Custard attacking, and the happy tea-time scene.
- Contrast - between the pets loud talk and their real fear, and between Custard's timid words and his brave action.

4. Moral

- Do not judge people by how they look or talk; real courage is shown in action.
- Being afraid does not mean you cannot be brave when the moment comes.
- Teasing someone for being shy or scared is unkind and unfair.
- A humble, quiet person can be the real hero in a crisis.

- True bravery means protecting others and doing your duty, even if you are scared inside.

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